

Understanding teaching the work of Mark Twain

BY JOHN NOGOWSKI

Yet another day goes by that I see Percival Everett's "James" sitting among a few other books in our bedroom, unopened and unread by me. And sure, I've had many people ask, "Have you read "Jim"?"

Some years ago, I wrote a book about my experiences teaching Mark Twain's "Adventures Of Huckleberry Finn" at a largely African-American school, a call that took some nerve but a decision that I remain immensely proud of all these years later. Might have been my best move as a teacher.

Though from what author Ron Chernow says in his new 1,037-page Mark Twain biography I'm currently wading through, Mr. Everett says "Anyone who wants to ban "Huck Finn" hasn't read it," I suppose it's out of loyalty and admiration for Mr. Twain, I can't make myself open the book. So far.

That may well also be because I'm not sure that even after all this time that America, heck, the world, has come to truly appreciate and maybe even celebrate the soulful, artistic, blindingly courageous spirit that Twain showed on twelve particular pages — Pg. 293-305 — of the "Adventures Of Huckleberry Finn" manuscript held in the Buffalo Erie County Public Library where Twain's manuscript is kept and conveniently digitized.

Pages, I might add, that come well before the famous "All right, then. I'll go to Hell" moment which doesn't come until Chapter 31. The moment I'm speaking of comes halfway there.

As we know, "Huck Finn" is one of a number of books that these moronic censors have banned from the very people who ought to be reading them, young people with open minds and hearts. For my money, no book written by an American author can — or will — get deeper into the soul of a young person, reading this along with a patient, understanding, compassionate educator than "Huck Finn." I say this from experience, teaching for a dozen years in what most would term "the worst high school in the state" with perpetually low test

scores, shoddy attendance and record — and perhaps understandable — teacher turnover.

The scene that I found often completely captivated, convinced and captured many of my students was in Chapter 15 where Huck, briefly separated from Jim due to a ferocious fog, a cleverly ironic choice by Twain because when Huck returns to the raft the two of them had been traversing the Mississippi on, he finds Jim disconsolate, “setting there with his head down between his knees, asleep, with his right arm hanging over the steering oar. The other oar was smashed off, and the raft was littered up with leaves and branches and dirt. So she’d had a rough time.”

And since Jim had been asleep, in a bit of a fog, you might say, when Jim awakes, he’s overjoyed that Huck is back and safe.

“Goodness, gracious, is dat you, Huck? En you ain’ dead – you ain’ drowneded — you’s back again? It’s too good for true, honey, it’s too good for true. Lemme look at you, chile, lemme feel o’ you. No, you ain’ dead! You’s back agin, live en soun’ jis de same ole Huck — de same ole Huck, thanks to goodness.”

Maybe uncomfortable by Jim’s joyous emotional welcome, Huck pretends that he’s been on the raft all along and two get into a wild story about what really happened, as if Jim wasn’t smart enough to know the difference. So Jim tries to explain everything with this “dream” about what occurred that Huck just can’t wait to puncture. Knowing this will humiliate Jim, Huck points out the trash, the branches and leaves on the raft, things left out of the “dream” and asks how did that happen, Jim?

“What do dey stan’ for?” Jim boldly responds. “I’s gwyne to tell you. When I got all wore out wid work, en wid de callin’ for you, en went to sleep, my heart wuz mos’ broke bekase you was los’, en I didn’ k’yer no mo’ what become er me en de raf’...En all you wuz thinkin’ bout wuz how you could make a fool uv ole Jim wid a lie. Dat truck dah is trash; en trash is what people is dat puts dirt on de head er dey fren’s en makes ‘em ashamed.”

Here’s where Twain has written himself to the edge of a literary cliff. Writing this just 20 years, maybe less, after the Civil War, where the most popular writer in America and one of the most successful and celebrated in the whole wide world has just had a white person attempt to insult the intelligence, the humanism, the love of a caring Black man, Twain knows what he must now do.

We do not know the actual numbers and never will. But is this the very first time in our literature, maybe any literature, that a white man had to apologize to a black? It may well be. You wonder if Twain’s hand shook as he brought the fountain pen to the top of Manuscript Page 305.

For he wrote “It was fifteen minutes before I could work myself up to go and humble myself to a n— — but I done it, and I warn’t ever sorry for it afterwards, neither. I didn’t do him no more mean tricks, and I wouldn’t done that one if I’d a knowed it would make him feel that way.”

Certainly, by the time we get to Chapter 31 and Huck, who has already tried to give Jim up, as he was taught by the elders in his time, tries to do it once more and can’t. And that’s where we get the famous scene “Alright then, I’ll go to Hell.” Which is deservedly one of the pivotal moments in the history of American Literature.

But in some ways, what happens in Chapter 15, the scene that starts on Page 293 of the Huck manuscript, is just as extraordinary. By first separating Huck from Jim, it gave the author the opportunity to show his readers that color has absolutely nothing to with affection between two people, particularly two people who felt like outcasts from society already.

When his writer’s instinct made him come up with a way to show the white man’s supposed superiority over a Black man with a mean-spirited prank and then, to completely turn that prank around enough to absolutely require an apology, that was artistic courage of the highest order. A writer who was risking his popularity, dignity, honor, perhaps even his financial future in order to have his characters behave the way humans truly should.

They can write all the prequels or sequels or rewrites of Huck Finn they want. They can lay into Twain — and they have — because he purposely used the epithet of the day, the N-word to show how insensitive, how degrading, how absolutely awful that word was then and, if you ask me, still is. Attention: Rappers.

In sitting in classrooms, sharing Twain’s story with young African-American students, many coming from difficult backgrounds, seeing them open their hearts and minds to this story from almost a century and half ago, it reached them in a way I couldn’t have anticipated or explained.

“Mr. Nogo,” one of them wrote, “Huck was the brother I never had.”

John Nogowski, who formerly wrote for the New Haven Register, is the author of “Teaching Huckleberry Finn,” currently available on Amazon, along with his new baseball book, “Diamond Duels.”